ISO 26000

Checklist

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Social responsibility is the responsibility of an organisation for the impacts of its decisions and activities on society and the environment through transparent and ethical behaviour. The goals of social responsibility are to support sustainable development, consider stakeholder expectations, comply with the law and international norms of behaviour, and ultimately integrate socially conscious practices throughout the organisation.

ISO 26000 provides organisations with guidance on how to incorporate social and environmental considerations into decision-making and be accountable for the impacts of their activities and decisions. In this checklist we provide a set of actions organisations can take to develop their social responsibility programmes in alignment with the recommendations set out by ISO 26000.

Step 1:

Understand the context of the organisation to identify how the organisation impacts society and the environment

Consider the organisation's:

- type, purpose, operations and size
- locations and relevant legal frameworks in those locations
- historical performance related to social responsibility
- workforce characteristics
- industry-relevant topics related to social responsibility, such as greenhouse gas emissions, conflict minerals and sustainable production
- current values
- existing value chain
- competitors and how they have addressed social responsibility.

Step 2:

Check and understand the organisation's current social responsibility strategy

Consider:

- existing definition(s) of social responsibility
- current leadership interest and commitment to social responsibility
- the level of existing encouragement for social responsibility across the workforce
- how the organisation has addressed social responsibility 'core subjects', including:

- human rights
- labour practices
- the environment
- fair operating practices
- consumer issues
- community involvement and development.

Step 3:

Engage stakeholders to determine their interests and expectations related to the core subjects and the organisation's operations

Examples of usual key stakeholders include:

- customers
- suppliers
- employees
- leadership
- public interest groups
- governments
- investors and shareholders
- competitors.

Step 4:

Determine and prioritise relevant social responsibility issues

Organisations should determine:

- the relevance of key social responsibility core topics based on:
  - organisational context analysis (see Step 1)
  - stakeholder engagement feedback (see Step 3)
- the priority of each core topic by accounting for:
  - the impact of the issue on stakeholders, sustainable development and organisational objectives

- the potential effect of taking action or failing to take action on the issue
- societal expectations regarding how each issue is managed
- the time needed to address the issue
- how easy it is to address the issue
- the cost to the organisation
- any legal/compliance obligations and penalties.

Step 5:

Develop or further implement a corporate governance strategy to promote social responsibility

Organisations should:

- create a governance and oversight structure
- set up committees and teams
- refine the organisation's social responsibility strategy (see Step 2)
- establish two-way communication with stakeholders to ensure feedback is received
- promote underrepresented groups to have a 'seat at the table' in guiding the social responsibility programme
- create incentives for promoting the programme
- document implementation decisions
- create a plan for continuous improvement.

Step 6:

Create a culture of social responsibility within the organisation

Among other things, this can be achieved by:

- establishing a clear connection between organisational values and social responsibility principles in ISO 26000
- setting up or further bolstering existing programmes on diversity, equality and inclusion (DEI), including goals and yearly progress
- setting up employee resource groups on social responsibility and DEI
- establishing or further supporting the organisation's charitable giving programme to raise funds in support of social responsibility causes.

Step 7:

Create or update the organisation's ethics programme to support social responsibility

Implement programmes and policies around:

- ethical behavioural standards from the organisation's employees, value chain and contractors in line with relevant laws and regulations
- conflict of interest processes
- the whistleblower/reporting programme
- anti-bribery (consider an ISO 37001 certification)
- fair competition.

Step 8:

Map out the organisational value chain and 'sphere of influence'

An organisation's sphere of influence is the range/extent of political, contractual, economic or other relationships through which an organisation has the ability to affect the decisions or activities of individuals or organisations. Evidence of actions taken to ensure social responsibility throughout the sphere of influence include:

- contractual provisions with suppliers
- website content or public statements promoting social responsibility
- community engagement
- investments
- knowledge sharing
- lobbying, media and social media
- participation in sector (trade) associations or industry groups
- joint projects.

Step 9:

Create or update social responsibility programme documents

All organisations should have the following documents and make them available on their website for public download:

- social responsibility policy
- annual report
- code of conduct or ethics

- annual corporate social responsibility or ESG report
- DEI policy and related statistics
- donations policy
- website page related to social responsibility
- health and safety policy
- anti-bribery policy
- data privacy policy
- conflict minerals policy
- artificial intelligence policy.

Step 10:

Reference and endorse global instruments on social responsibility

This can be done within the policies mentioned in Step 9. The global instruments that should be referenced include:

- the International Bill of Human Rights
- International Labour Organization Conventions
- the United Nations Guidelines for Consumer Protection
- the United Nations Global Compact.

Step 11:

Seek certification or accreditation on various social responsibility topics to demonstrate commitment

Examples include:

- ISO 26000 – Social Responsibility
- ISO 37001 – Anti-Bribery Management System
- ISO 37301 – Compliance Management System
- ISO 9001 – Quality Management System
- ISO 27001 – Information Security Management System
- ISO 14001 – Environmental Management System
- Energy Star
- B Corporation
- SA8000.

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About Speeki

Speeki helps companies design, build, manage, report and assure their non-financial business performance within an all-in-one sustainability management system. Covering over 20 different disciplines, Speeki helps companies drive better performance and create value from their non-financial initiatives.

With a platform to design, implement, monitor, measure, report and track non-financial initiatives, companies can focus on non-financial reporting, assurance and certification.

At Speeki, we use our proprietary Engage™ framework to help companies maximise their non-financial investment by making data-driven decisions that add value to their businesses and the planet.

Our mission is to help businesses integrate non-financial performance initiatives into their operations and create long-term value for their stakeholders. With Speeki, you can be confident that you are making informed decisions that align with your business goals, no matter where you are in your sustainability journey.

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